

GA-HR-09

Workplace Conflict Resolution & Respectful Communication

A clear standard for professional communication, collaborative conflict resolution, safe reporting, and fair accountability.

APPLIES TO

Gardner Academy employees and relevant staff

AUTHORITY

Gardner Academy workplace conduct standard

01 Purpose and principle

Gardner Academy recognises every employee's right to a safe and respectful work environment. Every employee therefore shares responsibility for speaking and acting professionally towards colleagues, even when there is pressure, frustration, disagreement, or a mistake.

02 Required communication standard

Employees must:

- Speak in a calm, professional, and respectful manner.
- Address the work, decision, behaviour, or impact rather than attacking the person.
- Listen without interrupting and make a reasonable effort to understand another perspective.
- Raise concerns directly and privately where appropriate, instead of arguing in front of students, families, or unrelated colleagues.
- Use approved supervision, grievance, safeguarding, or management channels when direct discussion is not appropriate or has not resolved the concern.

Prohibited conduct

Conflict must never involve:

- Threats, intimidation, coercion, or retaliation.
- Shouting, screaming, harsh or aggressive tones, or hostile gestures.
- Insults, humiliation, personal attacks, degrading remarks, or abusive language.
- Harassment, discrimination, bullying, or deliberate exclusion.
- Public confrontation that disrupts learning, undermines safety, or exposes students and families to internal staff disputes.
- Gossip, rumour-spreading, or recruiting colleagues to take sides instead of addressing the concern through the correct process.

Collaborative conflict resolution

For an ordinary workplace disagreement, employees should:

- Pause the discussion when emotions are too high for a respectful conversation.
- Arrange a suitable private time to discuss the concern.
- Describe the facts, explain the impact, and identify the work-related outcome needed.
- Listen to each person's perspective and agree on practical next steps, responsibilities, and follow-up.
- Ask a supervisor or neutral manager to facilitate when the matter remains unresolved or a direct conversation would not feel safe or appropriate.

Serious concerns and immediate escalation

An employee does not have to attempt informal resolution where there is a threat, violence, harassment, discrimination, serious bullying, retaliation, safeguarding concern, or significant power imbalance. These matters must be reported promptly to the appropriate manager or through the formal grievance, disciplinary, or safeguarding process. Immediate danger requires an immediate safety response.

Accountability and disciplinary action

A breach of this policy may result in disciplinary action under the Disciplinary Code and Procedure. The response will depend on the seriousness, impact, frequency, context, previous conduct, and any mitigating circumstances. Serious threats, violence, harassment, discrimination, or retaliation may constitute serious misconduct. No disciplinary sanction will be imposed without the applicable fair process.

No employee may be threatened, disadvantaged, isolated, or punished for raising a genuine concern, asking for assistance, participating honestly in a resolution process, or reporting conduct protected by this policy. Deliberately false or malicious allegations may be addressed separately through a fair process.